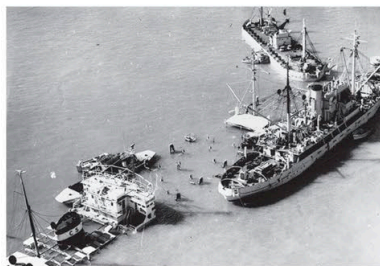


29 October 1956

START OF SUEZ CRISIS

After President Nasser of Egypt announced the nationalization of the Suez Canal, Britain and France responded by colluding with Israel to invade Egypt. In the face of US hostility, the European nations had to back down and withdraw their forces.

▽ Ships block the Suez canal

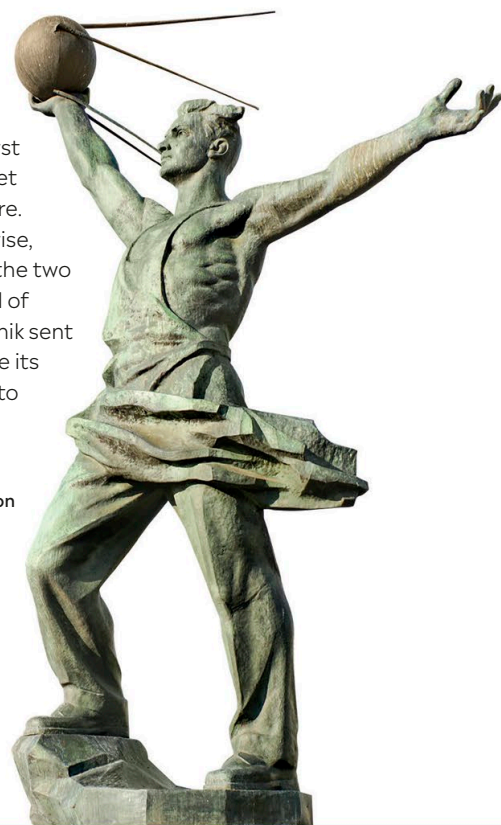


4 October 1957

LAUNCH OF SPUTNIK 1

Launched by Soviet scientists into low Earth orbit, Sputnik was the first artificial satellite to circle the planet beyond the limits of its atmosphere. Its success caught the US by surprise, triggering a Space Race between the two superpowers. Travelling at a speed of 29,000 km/h (18,000 mph), Sputnik sent back signals for three weeks before its batteries died. It finally fell back into the atmosphere early in 1958.

▷ Monument near Rizhskaya Metro station in Moscow celebrating Sputnik 1



1956

6 March 1957 Ghana, under Kwame Nkrumah, is the first former colony in sub-Saharan Africa to gain independence

June 1956 Egypt's President Nasser accepts Soviet aid to build the Aswan Dam

25 March 1957

THE TREATY OF ROME

Building on the success of the European Coal and Steel Community (1951), the six founder members – France, West Germany, Italy, Belgium, the Netherlands, and Luxembourg – broadened their alliance, creating a single market for goods and services. The result was the European Economic Community (EEC), which formed the basis of the later European Union (EU).



△ Ministers sign the treaty creating the EEC

January 1958

THE GREAT LEAP FORWARD

China's Mao Zedong launched a programme of reform, known as the "Great Leap Forward", intending to make China an industrial power that could match Britain and the United States. The people of rural China lived in massive communes where labour was pooled and many goods and services became free. The resulting policy distortions, combined with droughts and floods, brought about famine on a massive scale. Initially planned to last for five years, the campaign was abandoned after three.

